Q. There seems to be a perception that the NDA may face some losses in Maharashtra.

A. Uddhav Thackeray broke the alliance *dharma*. He stabbed the BJP in the back and became the CM. The people have not liked this. They may not say this openly, but will make their choice evident in the election. Later, we brought about a regime change in what was a practical move. Uddhavji used to sit at home and do his Facebook Live. He did not come to Mantralaya. We work 24X7. So, will people vote for those who work or those who sit at home?

Q. The linguistic divide in Mumbai seems to be getting stronger with a regional narrative.

A. The Opposition is trying to set a narrative and create a perception. The ground reality is different. They want to get Muslim support for the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA). Their propaganda will have an impact on the minority and the majority.

Q. Would you say the quality of our political discourse is falling in general?

A. I agree, in toto. They are unable to digest that their government has been toppled and Eknath Shinde is the CM. They must accept the reality. Why are people leaving them? Why have around 50 corporators from Mumbai joined us? We are being abused and pejoratives are being hurled at us. We have taken several decisions for Mumbai, to reduce pollution; we started dispensaries, cashless facilities in hospitals, and are providing quality healthcare.

Q. Major industrial projects like Vedanta-Foxconn left Maharashtra for Gujarat.

A. When did Vedanta go to Gujarat? When our government was just two months old. I had called Modi Saheb. He said such decisions are not taken in two months. These preparations take time and they had realised that the [MVA] government was not cooperating and supporting them. The decision was taken during the MVA's time. In the two years that it was in power, the state lagged in attracting FDI (foreign direct investment). Our government ensured that Maharashtra led in attracting FDI. We signed MoUs worth Rs 5 lakh crore at Davos in two years and 70 per cent of them are being executed.

"UDDHAV THACKERAY BROKE THE ALLIANCE DHARMA. HE STABBED THE BJP IN THE BACK AND BECAME THE CM. THE PEOPLE HAVE NOT LIKED THIS. THEY WILL MAKE THEIR CHOICE EVIDENT IN THE ELECTION"

Q. You mean there will be a counter-mobilisation from the majority?

A. Hundred per cent. Pakistani flags are being shown in their rallies. [1993 bomb blast convicts] Iqbal Moosa, Yaqub Memon's people and bomb blast accused can be seen there. The bomb blasts in Mumbai have killed innocents. They are taking along those who are accused of killing people. Questions are being raised over whether [then SIT chief Hemant] Karkare was killed by [Pakistani terrorist Ajmal] Kasab's bullets [in the 26/11 terror attacks]. This is an insult to our martyrs.

Q. The Maratha quota protests led to social unrest.

A. Pawar Saheb did not provide quotas to Marathas when he could. Many people benefitted from the support of the Maratha community and gained power, but kept the Marathas deprived. When I became the CM, I took this up on priority and said that Marathas would be given reservations without affecting the quota for OBCs (other backward classes). We convened a special session of the legislature and provided 10 per cent quotas to the Marathas. [Maratha activist Manoj] Jarange-Patil sought Kunbi certificates for Marathas that they were not getting in Marathwada. We started giving out these certificates and lakhs have received them so far.

"THEY ARE UNABLE TO DIGEST THAT THEIR GOVERNMENT HAS BEEN TOPPLED AND EKNATH SHINDE IS THE CM. THEY MUST ACCEPT THE REALITY. WHY ARE PEOPLE LEAVING THEM?"

Q. There are fears among weaker sections like the Dalits and tribals that the Constitution could be changed, that reservation will be done away with.

A. This narrative is being pushed by the Opposition. The Constitution framed by Babasaheb [Ambedkar] is the best in the world. The Congress amended the Constitution 83 times. They harassed Babasaheb, and defeated him twice. Modiji started marking 'Samvidhan Diwas'. He converted Babasaheb's dwelling in London into a memorial. We are developing his memorial in Mumbai. No one can change Babasaheb's Constitution even if they have 400 or 450 seats. It will remain till the sun and moon are there.

Q. It is said that you were in the reckoning for the CM's chair